

Checklist:

Team Topologies – Team Interaction Modes

Team Interaction Modes Checklist

Use this checklist for each **team-to-team** relationship.

1. Define the Interaction Clearly

- ☐ Identify the teams involved.
- ☐ Identify each team's topology: stream-aligned, enabling, complicated-subsystem, or platform.
- ☐ Decide the intended interaction mode: **Collaboration**, **X-as-a-Service**, or **Facilitating**.
- ☐ Make the interaction explicit so teams know what behavior is expected.
- ☐ Define who owns what responsibilities.
- ☐ Define the expected communication channels and cadence.
- ☐ Avoid requiring every team to communicate with every other team.
- ☐ Revisit the interaction mode as technology, organization size, market needs, or team experience changes.

2. Collaboration Mode Checklist

Use **Collaboration** when teams need close joint work, rapid discovery, innovation, or learning.

- ☐ There is significant uncertainty or novelty.
- ☐ The teams need to discover new approaches, patterns, or boundaries.

- ☐ The work benefits from high adaptability.
- ☐ Both teams have useful expertise to combine.
- ☐ The teams can work with high interaction and mutual respect.
- ☐ Responsibility is intentionally shared for the outcome of the collaboration.
- ☐ The collaboration is time-boxed or clearly limited.
- ☐ The team is collaborating with **at most one other team at a time**.
- ☐ The teams understand that boundaries may blur temporarily.
- ☐ The expected benefit justifies the higher cognitive load.
- ☐ There is a plan to reduce collaboration once boundaries or APIs become clearer.

Watch for:

- ☐ Collaboration continuing too long.
- ☐ Too much shared responsibility with unclear ownership.
- ☐ Excessive meetings or context-sharing overhead.
- ☐ A sign that team boundaries may be wrong.

3. X-as-a-Service Checklist

Use **X-as-a-Service** when one team provides a component, API, platform, tool, or capability that another team can consume with minimal collaboration.

- ☐ The service boundary is clear and well chosen.
- ☐ One team clearly provides the service.
- ☐ Another team clearly consumes the service.
- ☐ Day-to-day collaboration is minimal.
- ☐ The consuming team can use the service without needing deep implementation knowledge.
- ☐ The providing team manages the service like a product.
- ☐ The service has clear documentation.
- ☐ The service is easy to test, deploy, use, and debug.
- ☐ The developer experience is strong.
- ☐ Versioning and backward compatibility are considered.
- ☐ There is a roadmap or communication plan for future changes.
- ☐ Requests from consuming teams are considered but not automatically built.
- ☐ The service helps reduce cognitive load for consuming teams.

Watch for:

- ☐ Consumers need frequent help to use the service.
- ☐ The API or boundary is unclear.
- ☐ The service slows delivery instead of improving flow.
- ☐ Innovation across the boundary becomes too slow.
- ☐ The provider team lacks product or service management capabilities.

4. Facilitating Mode Checklist

Use **Facilitating** when one team helps another team improve, learn, unblock itself, or adopt new practices.

- ☐ One team needs help closing a capability gap.
- ☐ The facilitating team has relevant expertise.
- ☐ The goal is to make the helped team self-sufficient.
- ☐ The facilitating team is not taking ownership of the other team's main work.
- ☐ The interaction is focused on coaching, mentoring, enabling, or removing impediments.
- ☐ The facilitating team can detect gaps across multiple teams.
- ☐ The facilitating team works with only a small number of teams at the same time.
- ☐ Both teams understand the purpose and temporary nature of the facilitation.
- ☐ The helped team is open to learning and changing practices.

Watch for:

- ☐ The facilitating team becoming a permanent dependency.
- ☐ The helped team resisting assistance.
- ☐ The interaction feeling unclear, awkward, or unfamiliar.
- ☐ The facilitator doing the work instead of enabling the team.

5. Match Modes to Team Types

Stream-Aligned Teams

- ☐ Typically use **Collaboration** with other teams when discovery is needed.
- ☐ Typically consume capabilities through **X-as-a-Service**.
- ☐ Occasionally receive **Facilitation** to improve capabilities.

Enabling Teams

- ☐ Typically use **Facilitating** mode.
- ☐ Occasionally use **Collaboration** to jointly discover or shape practices.

Complicated-Subsystem Teams

- ☐ Typically provide capabilities through **X-as-a-Service**.
- ☐ Occasionally use **Collaboration** when discovery or boundary refinement is needed.

Platform Teams

- ☐ Typically provide the platform through **X-as-a-Service**.
- ☐ Occasionally use **Collaboration** to discover or refine platform capabilities.

6. Team Behavior Checklist

Collaboration Behavior

- ☐ Teams interact frequently.
- ☐ Teams show mutual respect.
- ☐ Teams are willing to share responsibility.
- ☐ Teams use practices such as pairing, mobbing, workshops, or whiteboarding when useful.
- ☐ Teams avoid blame when boundaries are unclear.

X-as-a-Service Behavior

- ☐ The provider team focuses on the user and developer experiences.
- ☐ The consumer team gives clear feedback.
- ☐ The provider team treats the service as a product.
- ☐ The interaction is low-friction and predictable.

Facilitating Behavior

- ☐ The facilitating team helps without taking over.
- ☐ The receiving team is open to being helped.

- ☐ The goal is capability growth, not permanent dependency.
- ☐ Both teams agree on what “self-sufficient” looks like.

7. Evolution and Improvement Checklist

- ☐ Use collaboration temporarily to discover better service boundaries.
- ☐ Move from collaboration to X-as-a-Service once the boundary is stable.
- ☐ Use facilitating teams to support new structures during a Reverse Conway maneuver.
- ☐ Temporarily change interaction modes to build empathy and experience.
- ☐ Treat awkward interactions as signals of missing capabilities or misplaced boundaries.
- ☐ Ask whether the current mode is helping flow or creating friction.
- ☐ Review whether the interaction mode still fits the current architecture.
- ☐ Review whether the team boundaries still make sense.
- ☐ Use techniques like event storming or context mapping to clarify boundaries.

Final Review

- ☐ Every important team interaction has an explicit mode.
- ☐ Teams know whether they are collaborating, consuming/providing a service, or facilitating.
- ☐ Responsibilities are clear.
- ☐ Boundaries are clear enough for the current stage of work.
- ☐ Communication is intentional, not accidental.
- ☐ The interaction mode supports fast flow.
- ☐ The organization is ready to evolve team structures and interaction modes when needed.

